reader bearing a Christian name wrote to tell me that when his brother was getting married to a Hindu girl, the Hindu priest made a point of saying to him before the ceremony words to the effect of: ‘When I say god, I don’t mean a particular god.’ As this reader commented: ‘it’s at moments like that that I can’t help but feel proud to be Indian and to be moved by its religiosity—even though I’m an atheist.’

The real alternatives in our country are between those who believe in an India where differences arising from your birth, language, social status, mode of worship or dietary preferences shouldn’t determine your Indianness, and those who define Indianness along one or more of these divisions. In other words the really important debate is not about conversions, but between the unifiers and the dividers—between those who think all Indians are ‘us’, whichever God they choose to worship, and those who think that Indians can be divided into ‘us’ and ‘them’.

It is time for all Hindus to say: stop the politics of division.

We are *all* Indians.